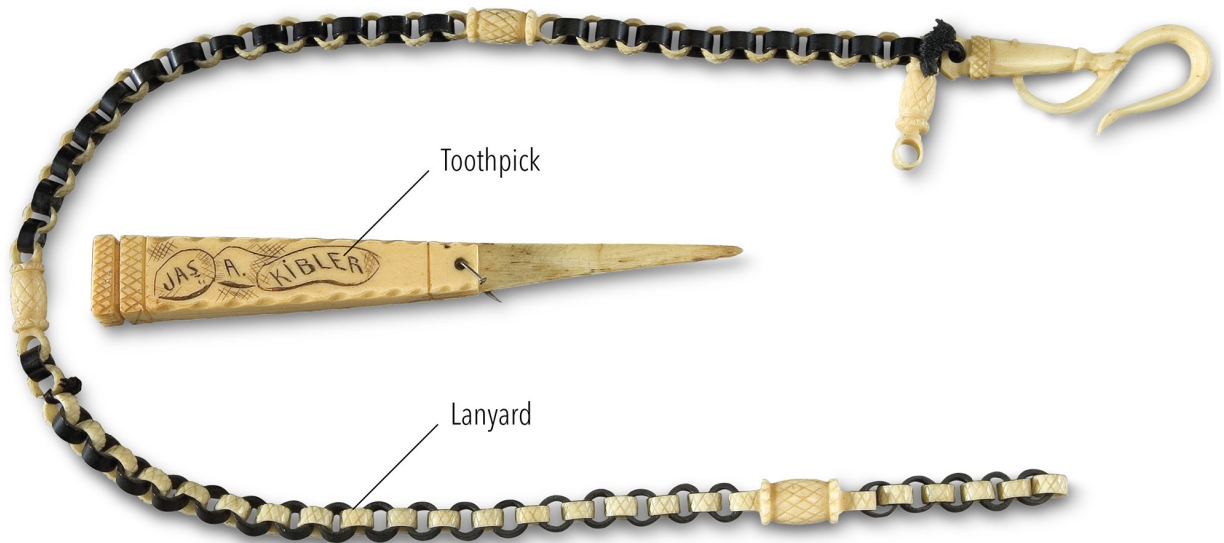


bureaucratic fecklessness and a dire lack of resources: poor food, shelter, hygiene, and medical attention. Thousands of men died.



Prisoner carvings

James Allen Kibler, a Confederate prisoner of war held in Fort Delaware near Philadelphia, carved this toothpick and decorated lanyard. Carving helped captives while away the long hours.

Mixed fortunes

Early in the war the best-known Confederate prisoner-of-war camp was Richmond's Libby Prison. Some 125,000 Union prisoners may have passed through this grim, three-story brick warehouse and former ship's chandlery, for Libby was a prisoner processing station, from which captives were sent on to other camps across the South. Within its dank, fetid walls it had room for about 1,000 inmates, but upwards of five times that number congregated in the rat-infested corridors. Almost all were officers, educated men who subsequently wrote many accounts of their experiences as prisoners of war. They were the lucky ones; they had only to look out their barred windows to see how the other half lived. Out there, Belle Isle "prison" could be glimpsed, a rocky outcropping in the midst of the James River rapids. This was the other extreme, a natural prison with few or no facilities on which congregated perhaps 8,000 enlisted men, scrambling for the shelter of only 3,000 tents and a handful of shacks. Conditions at Illinois' Rock Island, in the middle